

'I don't know what you mean, nor do I even desire to know what you mean,' replied the cardinal; 'but I wish to please you, and see nothing out of the way in giving you what you demand with respect to so infamous a creature—the more so as you tell me this D'Arragnan is a libertine, a duelist, and a traitor.'

'An infamous scoundrel, monseigneur, a scoundrel!'

'Give me paper, a quill, and some ink, then,' said the cardinal.

'Here they are, monseigneur.'

There was a moment of silence, which proved that the cardinal was employed in seeking the terms in which he should write the note, or else in writing it. Athos, who had not lost a word of the conversation, took his two companions by the hand, and led them to the other end of the room.

'Well,' said Porthos, 'what do you want, and why do you not let us listen to the end of the conversation?'

'Hush!' said Athos, speaking in a low voice. 'We have heard all it was necessary we should hear; besides, I don't prevent you from listening, but I must be gone.'

'You must be gone!' said Porthos; 'and if the cardinal asks for you, what answer can we make?'

'You will not wait till he asks; you will speak first, and tell him that I am gone on the lookout, because certain expressions of our host have given me reason to think the road is not safe. I will say two words about it to the cardinal's esquire likewise. The rest concerns myself; don't be uneasy about that.'

'Be prudent, Athos,' said Aramis.

'Be easy on that head,' replied Athos; 'you know I am cool enough.'

Porthos and Aramis resumed their places by the stovepipe.

As to Athos, he went out without any mystery, took his horse, which was tied with those of his friends to the fastenings of the shutters, in four words convinced the attendant of the necessity of a vanguard for their return, carefully examined the priming of his pistols, drew his sword, and took, like a forlorn hope, the road to the camp.

Chapter XLV A Conjugal Scene



As Athos had foreseen, it was not long before the cardinal came down. He opened the door of the room in which the Musketeers were, and found Porthos playing an earnest game of dice with Aramis. He cast a rapid glance around the room, and perceived that one of his men was missing. 'What has become of Monseigneur Athos?' asked he.

'Monseigneur,' replied Porthos, 'he has gone as a scout, on account of some words of our host, which made him believe the road was not safe.'

'And you, what have you done, Monsieur Porthos?'

'I have won five pistols of Aramis.'

'Well; now will you return with me?'

'We are at your Eminence's orders.'

'To horse, then, gentlemen; for it is getting late.'

The attendant was at the door, holding the cardinal's horse by the bridle. At a short distance a group of two men and three horses appeared in the shade. These were the two men who were to conduct Milady to Fort La Pointe, and superintend her embarkation.

The attendant confirmed to the cardinal what the two Musketeers had already said with respect to Athos. The cardinal made an approving gesture, and retraced his route with the same precautions he had used in coming.

Let us leave him to follow the road to the camp protected by his esquire and the two Musketeers, and return to Athos.

For a hundred paces he maintained the speed at which he started; but when out of sight he turned his horse to the right, made a circuit, and came back within twenty paces of a high hedge to watch the passage of

the little troop. Having recognized the laced hats of his companions and the golden fringe of the cardinal's cloak, he waited till the horsemen had turned the angle of the road, and having lost sight of them, he returned at a gallop to the inn, which was opened to him without hesitation.

The host recognized him.

'My officer,' said Athos, 'has forgotten to give a piece of very important information to the lady, and has sent me back to repair his forgetfulness.'

'Go up,' said the host; 'she is still in her chamber.'

Athos availed himself of the permission, ascended the stairs with his lightest step, gained the landing, and through the open door perceived Milady putting on her hat.

He entered the chamber and closed the door behind him. At the noise he made in pushing the bolt, Milady turned round.

Athos was standing before the door, enveloped in his cloak, with his hat pulled down over his eyes. On seeing this figure, mute and immovable as a statue, Milady was frightened.

'Who are you, and what do you want?' cried she.

'Humph,' murmured Athos, 'it is certainly she!'

And letting fall his cloak and raising his hat, he advanced toward Milady.

'Do you know me, madame?' said he.

Milady made one step forward, and then drew back as if she had seen a serpent.

'So far, well,' said Athos, 'I perceive you know me.'

'The Comte de la Fère!' murmured Milady, becoming exceedingly pale, and drawing back till the wall prevented her from going any farther.

'Yes, Milady,' replied Athos; 'the Comte de la Fère in person, who comes expressly from the other world to have the pleasure of paying you a visit. Sit down, madame, and let us talk, as the cardinal said.'

Milady, under the influence of inexpressible terror, sat down without uttering a word.

'You certainly are a demon sent upon the earth!' said Athos. 'Your power is great, I know; but you also know that with the help of God men have often conquered the most terrible demons. You have once before thrown yourself in my path. I thought I had crushed you, madame; but either I was deceived or hell has resuscitated you!'

'Yes, to a convent.'

'And to which?'

'I don't know; the secret has been well kept.'

'But I will know!'

'And your Eminence will tell me in what convent that woman is?'

'I can see nothing inconvenient in that,' said the cardinal.

'Well, now I have an enemy much more to be dreaded by me than this little Madame Bonacieux.'

'Who is that?'

'Her lover.'

'What is his name?'

'Oh, your Eminence knows him well,' cried Milady, carried away by her anger. 'He is the evil genius of both of us. It is he who in an encounter with your Eminence's Guards decided the victory in favour of the king's Musketeers; it is he who gave three desperate wounds to De Wardes, your emissary, and who caused the affair of the diamond studs to fail; it is he who, knowing it was I who had Madame Bonacieux carried off, has sworn my death.'

'Ah, ah!' said the cardinal, 'I know of whom you speak.'

'I mean that miserable D'Aragnan.'

'He is a bold fellow,' said the cardinal.

'And it is exactly because he is a bold fellow that he is the more to be feared.'

'I must have,' said the duke, 'a proof of his connection with Buckingham.'

'A proof?' cried Milady; 'I will have ten.'

'Well, then, it becomes the simplest thing in the world; get me that proof, and I will send him to the Bastille.'

'So far good, monseigneur; but afterwards?'

'When once in the Bastille, there is no afterward!' said the cardinal, in a low voice. 'Ah, *pardieu*!' continued he, 'if it were as easy for me to get rid of my enemy as it is easy to get rid of yours, and if it were against such people you require impunity—'

'Monseigneur,' replied Milady, 'a fair exchange. Life for life, man for man; give me one, I will give you the other.'

‘Well,’ said the cardinal, ‘then it will be time to claim the order which you just now required.’

‘Your Eminence is right,’ replied Milady; ‘and I have been wrong in seeing in the mission with which you honour me anything but that which it really is—that is, to announce to his Grace, on the part of your Eminence, that you are acquainted with the different disguises by means of which he succeeded in approaching the queen during the fête given by Madame the Constable; that you have proofs of the interview granted at the Louvre by the queen to a certain Italian astrologer who was no other than the Duke of Buckingham; that you have ordered a little romance of a satirical nature to be written upon the adventures of Amiens, with a plan of the gardens in which those adventures took place, and portraits of the actors who figured in them; that Montague is in the Bastille, and that the torture may make him say things he remembers, and even things he has forgotten; that you possess a certain letter from Madame de Chevreuse, found in his Grace’s lodging, which singularly compromises not only her who wrote it, but her in whose name it was written. Then, if he persists, notwithstanding all this—as that is, as I have said, the limit of my mission—I shall have nothing to do but to pray God to work a miracle for the salvation of France. That is it, is it not, monseigneur, and I shall have nothing else to do?’

‘That is it,’ replied the cardinal, dryly.

‘And now,’ said Milady, without appearing to remark the change of the duke’s tone toward her—‘now that I have received the instructions of your Eminence as concerns your enemies, Monseigneur will permit me to say a few words to him of mine?’

‘Have you enemies, then?’ asked Richelieu.

‘Yes, monseigneur, enemies against whom you owe me all your support, for I made them by serving your Eminence.’

‘Who are they?’ replied the duke.

‘In the first place, there is a little *intrigante* named Bonacieux.’

‘She is in the prison of Nantes.’

‘That is to say, she was there,’ replied Milady; ‘but the queen has obtained an order from the king by means of which she has been conveyed to a convent.’

‘To a convent?’ said the duke.

Milady at these words, which recalled frightful remembrances, hung down her head with a suppressed groan.

‘Yes, hell has resuscitated you,’ continued Athos. ‘Hell has made you rich, hell has given you another name, hell has almost made you another face; but it has neither effaced the stains from your soul nor the brand from your body.’

Milady arose as if moved by a powerful spring, and her eyes flashed lightning. Athos remained sitting.

‘You believed me to be dead, did you not, as I believed you to be? And the name of Athos as well concealed the Comte de la Fère, as the name Milady Clarik concealed Anne de Breuil. Was it not so you were called when your honoured brother married us? Our position is truly a strange one,’ continued Athos, laughing. ‘We have only lived up to the present time because we believed each other dead, and because a remembrance is less oppressive than a living creature, though a remembrance is sometimes devouring.’

‘But,’ said Milady, in a hollow, faint voice, ‘what brings you back to me, and what do you want with me?’

‘I wish to tell you that though remaining invisible to your eyes, I have not lost sight of you.’

‘You know what I have done?’

‘I can relate to you, day by day, your actions from your entrance to the service of the cardinal to this evening.’

A smile of incredulity passed over the pale lips of Milady.

‘Listen! It was you who cut off the two diamond studs from the shoulder of the Duke of Buckingham; it was you who had Madame Bonacieux carried off; it was you who, in love with De Wardes and thinking to pass the night with him, opened the door to Monsieur D’Aragnan; it was you who, believing that De Wardes had deceived you, wished to have him killed by his rival; it was you who, when this rival had discovered your infamous secret, wished to have him killed in his turn by two assassins, whom you sent in pursuit of him; it was you who, finding the balls had missed their mark, sent poisoned wine with a forged letter, to make your victim believe that the wine came from his friends. In short, it was you who have but now in this chamber, seated in this chair I now fill, made an engagement with Cardinal Richelieu to cause the Duke of Buckingham

to be assassinated, in exchange for the promise he has made you to allow you to assassinate D'Arragnan.'

Milady was livid.

'You must be Satan!' cried she.

'Perhaps,' said Athos, 'But at all events listen well to this. Assassinate the Duke of Buckingham, or cause him to be assassinated—I care very little about that! I don't know him. Besides, he is an Englishman. But do not touch with the tip of your finger a single hair of D'Arragnan, who is a faithful friend whom I love and defend, or I swear to you by the head of my father the crime which you shall have endeavoured to commit, or shall have committed, shall be the last.'

'Monsieur D'Arragnan has cruelly insulted me,' said Milady, in a hollow tone; 'Monsieur D'Arragnan shall die!'

'Indeed! Is it possible to insult you, madame?' said Athos, laughing; 'he has insulted you, and he shall die!'

'He shall die!' replied Milady; 'she first, and he afterward.'

Athos was seized with a kind of vertigo. The sight of this creature, who had nothing of the woman about her, recalled awful remembrances. He thought how one day, in a less dangerous situation than the one in which he was now placed, he had already endeavoured to sacrifice her to his honour. His desire for blood returned, burning his brain and pervading his frame like a raging fever; he arose in his turn, reached his hand to his belt, drew forth a pistol, and cocked it.

Milady, pale as a corpse, endeavoured to cry out; but her swollen tongue could utter no more than a hoarse sound which had nothing human in it and resembled the rattle of a wild beast. Motionless against the dark tapestry, with her hair in disorder, she appeared like a horrid image of terror.

Athos slowly raised his pistol, stretched out his arm so that the weapon almost touched Milady's forehead, and then, in a voice the more terrible from having the supreme calmness of a fixed resolution, 'Madame,' said he, 'you will this instant deliver to me the paper the cardinal signed; or upon my soul, I will blow your brains out.'

With another man, Milady might have preserved some doubt; but she knew Athos. Nevertheless, she remained motionless.

'You have one second to decide,' said he.

'There will be, in all times and in all countries, particularly if religious divisions exist in those countries, fanatics who ask nothing better than to become martyrs. Ay, and observe—it just occurs to me that the Puritans are furious against Buckingham, and their preachers designate him as the Antichrist.'

'Well?' said Milady.

'Well,' continued the cardinal, in an indifferent tone, 'the only thing to be sought for at this moment is some woman, handsome, young, and clever, who has cause of quarrel with the duke. The duke has had many affairs of gallantry; and if he has fostered his amours by promises of eternal constancy, he must likewise have sown the seeds of hatred by his eternal infidelities.'

'No doubt,' said Milady, coolly, 'such a woman may be found.'

'Well, such a woman, who would place the knife of Jacques Clément or of Ravalliac in the hands of a fanatic, would save France.'

'Yes; but she would then be the accomplice of an assassination.'

'Were the accomplices of Ravalliac or of Jacques Clément ever known?'

'No; for perhaps they were too high-placed for anyone to dare look for them where they were. The Palace of Justice would not be burned down for everybody, monseigneur.'

'You think, then, that the fire at the Palace of Justice was not caused by chance?' asked Richelieu, in the tone with which he would have put a question of no importance.

'I, monseigneur?' replied Milady. 'I think nothing; I quote a fact, that is all. Only I say that if I were named Madame de Montpensier, or the Queen Marie de Médicis, I should use less precautions than I take, being simply called Milady Clarik.'

'That is just,' said Richelieu. 'What do you require, then?'

'I require an order which would ratify beforehand all that I should think proper to do for the greatest good of France.'

'But in the first place, this woman I have described must be found who is desirous of avenging herself upon the duke.'

'She is found,' said Milady.

'Then the miserable fanatic must be found who will serve as an instrument of God's justice.'

'He will be found.'

'Your Eminence will judge: the ball of Madame the Constable; the night at the Louvre; the evening at Amiens; the arrest of Montague; the letter of Madame de Chevreuse.'

'That's it,' said the cardinal, 'that's it. You have an excellent memory, Milady.'

'But,' resumed she to whom the cardinal addressed this flattering compliment, 'if, in spite of all these reasons, the duke does not give way and continues to menace France?'

'The duke is in love to madness, or rather to folly,' replied Richelieu, with great bitterness. 'Like the ancient paladins, he has only undertaken this war to obtain a look from his lady's love. If he becomes certain that this war will cost the honour, and perhaps the liberty, of the lady of his thoughts, as he says, I will answer for it he will look twice.'

'And yet,' said Milady, with a persistence that proved she wished to see clearly to the end of the mission with which she was about to be charged, 'if he persists?'

'If he persists?' said the cardinal. 'That is not probable.'

'It is possible,' said Milady.

'If he persists—' His Eminence made a pause, and resumed: 'If he persists—well, then I shall hope for one of those events which change the destinies of states.'

'If your Eminence would quote to me some one of these events in history,' said Milady, 'perhaps I should partake of your confidence as to the future.'

'Well, here, for example,' said Richelieu: 'when, in 1610, for a cause similar to that which moves the duke, King Henry IV, of glorious memory, was about, at the same time, to invade Flanders and Italy, in order to attack Austria on both sides. Well, did there not happen an event which saved Austria? Why should not the king of France have the same chance as the emperor?'

'Your Eminence means, I presume, the knife stab in the Rue de la Feronnerie?'

'Precisely,' said the cardinal.

'Does not your Eminence fear that the punishment inflicted upon Ravalliac may deter anyone who might entertain the idea of imitating him?'

Milady saw by the contraction of his countenance that the trigger was about to be pulled; she reached her hand quickly to her bosom, drew out a paper, and held it toward Athos.

'Take it,' said she, 'and be accursed!'

Athos took the paper, returned the pistol to his belt, approached the lamp to be assured that it was the paper, unfolded it, and read:

Dec. 3, 1627

It is by my order and for the good of the state that the bearer of this has done what he has done.

RICHELIEU

'And now,' said Athos, resuming his cloak and putting on his hat, 'now that I have drawn your teeth, viper, bite if you can.'

And he left the chamber without once looking behind him.

At the door he found the two men and the spare horse which they held. 'Gentlemen,' said he, 'Monseigneur's order is, you know, to conduct that woman, without losing time, to Fort La Pointe, and never to leave her till she is on board.'

As these words agreed wholly with the order they had received, they bowed their heads in sign of assent.

With regard to Athos, he leaped lightly into the saddle and set out at full gallop; only instead of following the road, he went across the fields, urging his horse to the utmost and stopping occasionally to listen.

In one of those halts he heard the steps of several horses on the road. He had no doubt it was the cardinal and his escort. He immediately made a new point in advance, rubbed his horse down with some heath and leaves of trees, and placed himself across the road, about two hundred paces from the camp.

'Who goes there?' cried he, as soon as he perceived the horsemen.

'That is our brave Musketeer, I think,' said the cardinal.

'Yes, monseigneur,' said Porthos, 'it is he.'

'Monsieur Athos,' said Richelieu, 'receive my thanks for the good guard you have kept. Gentlemen, we are arrived; take the gate on the left. The watchword is, "King and Ré."'

Saying these words, the cardinal saluted the three friends with an inclination of his head, and took the right hand, followed by his attendant—for that night he himself slept in the camp.

‘Well!’ said Porthos and Aramis together, as soon as the cardinal was out of hearing, ‘well, he signed the paper she required!’

‘I know it,’ said Athos, coolly, ‘since here it is.’

And the three friends did not exchange another word till they reached their quarters, except to give the watchword to the sentinels. Only they sent Mousqueton to tell Planchet that his master was requested, the instant that he left the trenches, to come to the quarters of the Musketeers.

Milady, as Athos had foreseen, on finding the two men that awaited her, made no difficulty in following them. She had had for an instant an inclination to be reconducted to the cardinal, and relate everything to him; but a revelation on her part would bring about a revelation on the part of Athos. She might say that Athos had hanged her; but then Athos would tell that she was branded. She thought it was best to preserve silence, to discreetly set off to accomplish her difficult mission with her usual skills, and then, all things being accomplished to the satisfaction of the cardinal, to come to him and claim her vengeance.

In consequence, after having travelled all night, at seven o’clock she was at the fort of the Point; at eight o’clock she had embarked; and at nine, the vessel, which with letters of marque from the cardinal was supposed to be sailing for Bayonne, raised anchor, and steered its course toward England.

‘Will he believe that your Eminence is in a position to accomplish the threat thus made?’

‘Yes; for I have the proofs.’

‘I must be able to present these proofs for his appreciation.’

‘Without doubt. And you will tell him I will publish the report of Bois-Robert and the Marquis de Beaurtu, upon the interview which the duke had at the residence of Madame the Constable with the queen on the evening Madame the Constable gave a masquerade. You will tell him, in order that he may not doubt, that he came there in the costume of the Great Mogul, which the Chevalier de Guise was to have worn, and that he purchased this exchange for the sum of three thousand pistoles.’

‘Well, monseigneur?’

‘All the details of his coming into and going out of the palace—on the night when he introduced himself in the character of an Italian fortune teller—you will tell him, that he may not doubt the correctness of my information; that he had under his cloak a large white robe dotted with black tears, death’s heads, and crossbones—for in case of a surprise, he was to pass for the phantom of the White Lady who, as all the world knows, appears at the Louvre every time any great event is impending.’

‘Is that all, monseigneur?’

‘Tell him also that I am acquainted with all the details of the adventure at Amiens; that I will have a little romance made of it, wittily turned, with a plan of the garden and portraits of the principal actors in that nocturnal romance.’

‘I will tell him that.’

‘Tell him further that I hold Montague in my power; that Montague is in the Bastille; that no letters were found upon him, it is true, but that torture may make him tell much of what he knows, and even what he does not know.’

‘Exactly.’

‘Then add that his Grace has, in the precipitation with which he quit the Isle of Ré, forgotten and left behind him in his lodging a certain letter from Madame de Chevreuse which singularly compromises the queen, inasmuch as it proves not only that her Majesty can love the enemies of the king but that she can conspire with the enemies of France. You recollect perfectly all I have told you, do you not?’

‘I must go thither tonight?’

‘Instantly! That is to say, when you have received my instructions. Two men, whom you will find at the door on going out, will serve you as escort. You will allow me to leave first; then, after half an hour, you can go away in your turn.’

‘Yes, monseigneur. Now let us return to the mission with which you wish to charge me; and as I desire to continue to merit the confidence of your Eminence, deign to unfold it to me in terms clear and precise, that I may not commit an error.’

There was an instant of profound silence between the two interlocutors. It was evident that the cardinal was weighing beforehand the terms in which he was about to speak, and that Milady was collecting all her intellectual faculties to comprehend the things he was about to say, and to engrave them in her memory when they should be spoken.

Athos took advantage of this moment to tell his two companions to fasten the door inside, and to make them a sign to come and listen with him.

The two Musketeers, who loved their ease, brought a chair for each of themselves and one for Athos. All three then sat down with their heads together and their ears on the alert.

‘You will go to London,’ continued the cardinal. ‘Arrived in London, you will seek Buckingham.’

‘I must beg your Eminence to observe,’ said Milady, ‘that since the affair of the diamond studs, about which the duke always suspected me, his Grace distrusts me.’

‘Well, this time,’ said the cardinal, ‘it is not necessary to steal his confidence, but to present yourself frankly and loyally as a negotiator.’

‘Frankly and loyally,’ repeated Milady, with an unspeakable expression of duplicity.

‘Yes, frankly and loyally,’ replied the cardinal, in the same tone. ‘All this negotiation must be carried on openly.’

‘I will follow your Eminence’s instructions to the letter. I only wait till you give them.’

‘You will go to Buckingham in my behalf, and you will tell him I am acquainted with all the preparations he has made; but that they give me no uneasiness, since at the first step he takes I will ruin the queen.’

Chapter XLVI

The Bastion Saint-Gervais



ON arriving at the lodgings of his three friends, D’Arragnan found them assembled in the same chamber. Athos was meditating; Porthos was twisting his moustache; Aramis was saying his prayers in a charming little Book of Hours, bound in blue velvet.

‘*Pardieu*, gentlemen,’ said he. ‘I hope what you have to tell me is worth the trouble, or else, I warn you, I will not pardon you for making me come here instead of getting a little rest after a night spent in taking and dismantling a bastion. Ah, why were you not there, gentlemen? It was warm work.’

‘We were in a place where it was not very cold,’ replied Porthos, giving his moustache a twist which was peculiar to him.

‘Hush!’ said Athos.

‘Oh, oh!’ said D’Arragnan, comprehending the slight frown of the Musketeer. ‘It appears there is something fresh aboard.’

‘Aramis,’ said Athos, ‘you went to breakfast the day before yesterday at the inn of the Parpailloz, I believe?’

‘Yes.’

‘How did you fare?’

‘For my part, I ate but little. The day before yesterday was a fish day, and they had nothing but meat.’

‘What,’ said Athos, ‘no fish at a seaport?’

‘They say,’ said Aramis, resuming his pious reading, ‘that the dyke which the cardinal is making drives them all out into the open sea.’

‘But that is not quite what I mean to ask you, Aramis,’ replied Athos. ‘I want to know if you were left alone, and nobody interrupted you.’

‘Why, I think there were not many intruders. Yes, Athos, I know what you mean: we shall do very well at the Parpailot.’

‘Let us go to the Parpailot, then, for here the walls are like sheets of paper.’

D’Artagnan, who was accustomed to his friend’s manner of acting, and who perceived immediately, by a word, a gesture, or a sign from him, that the circumstances were serious, took Athos’s arm, and went out without saying anything. Porthos followed, chatting with Aramis.

On their way they met Grimaud. Athos made him a sign to come with them. Grimaud, according to custom, obeyed in silence; the poor lad had nearly come to the pass of forgetting how to speak.

They arrived at the drinking room of the Parpailot. It was seven o’clock in the morning, and daylight began to appear. The three friends ordered breakfast, and went into a room in which the host said they would not be disturbed.

Unfortunately, the hour was badly chosen for a private conference. The morning drum had just been beaten; everyone shook off the drowsiness of night, and to dispel the humid morning air, came to take a drop at the inn. Dragons, Swiss, Guardsmen, Musketeers, light-horsemen, succeeded one another with a rapidity which might answer the purpose of the host very well, but agreed badly with the views of the four friends. Thus they applied very curtsy to the salutations, healths, and jokes of their companions.

‘I see how it will be,’ said Athos: ‘we shall get into some pretty quarrel or other, and we have no need of one just now. D’Artagnan, tell us what sort of a night you have had, and we will describe ours afterward.’

‘Ah, yes,’ said a light-horseman, with a glass of brandy in his hand, which he sipped slowly. ‘I hear you gentlemen of the Guards have been in the trenches tonight, and that you did not get much the best of the Rochellais.’

D’Artagnan looked at Athos to know if he ought to reply to this intruder who thus mixed unasked in their conversation.

‘Well,’ said Athos, ‘don’t you hear Monsieur de Busigny, who does you the honour to ask you a question? Relate what has passed during the night, since these gentlemen desire to know it.’

Chapter XLIV

The Utility of Stovepipes



It was evident that without suspecting it, and actuated solely by their chivalrous and adventurous character, our three friends had just rendered a service to someone the cardinal honoured with his special protection.

Now, who was that someone? That was the question the three Musketeers put to one another. Then, seeing that none of their replies could throw any light on the subject, Porthos called the host and asked for dice.

Porthos and Aramis placed themselves at the table and began to play.

Athos walked about in a contemplative mood.

While thinking and walking, Athos passed and repassed before the pipe of the stove, broken in halves, the other extremity passing into the chamber above; and every time he passed and repassed he heard a murmur of words, which at length fixed his attention. Athos went close to it, and distinguished some words that appeared to merit so great an interest that he made a sign to his friends to be silent, remaining himself bent with his ear directed to the opening of the lower orifice.

‘Listen, Milady,’ said the cardinal, ‘the affair is important. Sit down, and let us talk it over.’

‘Milady!’ murmured Athos.

‘I listen to your Eminence with greatest attention,’ replied a female voice which made the Musketeer start.

‘A small vessel with an English crew, whose captain is on my side, awaits you at the mouth of Charente, at Fort La Pointe¹. He will set sail tomorrow morning.’

¹Fort La Pointe, or Fort Vaseau, was not built until 1672, nearly 50 years later.

A man, enveloped in a cloak, came out immediately, and exchanged some rapid words with the cardinal; after which he mounted his horse, and set off in the direction of Surgères, which was likewise the way to Paris.

‘Advance, gentlemen,’ said the cardinal.

‘You have told me the truth, my gentlemen,’ said he, addressing the Musketeers, ‘and it will not be my fault if our encounter this evening be not advantageous to you. In the meantime, follow me.’

The cardinal alighted; the three Musketeers did likewise. The cardinal threw the bridle of his horse to his esquire; the three Musketeers fastened the horses to the shutters.

The host stood at the door. For him, the cardinal was only an officer coming to visit a lady.

‘Have you any chamber on the ground floor where these gentlemen can wait near a good fire?’ said the cardinal.

The host opened the door of a large room, in which an old stove had just been replaced by a large and excellent chimney.

‘I have this,’ said he.

‘That will do,’ replied the cardinal. ‘Enter, gentlemen, and be kind enough to wait for me; I shall not be more than half an hour.’

And while the three Musketeers entered the ground floor room, the cardinal, without asking further information, ascended the staircase like a man who has no need of having his road pointed out to him.

‘Have you not taken a bastion?’ said a Swiss, who was drinking rum out of a beer glass.

‘Yes, monsieur,’ said D’Artagnan, bowing, ‘we have had that honour. We even have, as you may have heard, introduced a barrel of powder under one of the angles, which in blowing up made a very pretty breach. Without reckoning that as the bastion was not built yesterday all the rest of the building was badly shaken.’

‘And what bastion is it?’ asked a dragoon, with his saber run through a goose which he was taking to be cooked.

‘The bastion St. Gervais,’ replied D’Artagnan, ‘from behind which the Rochellais annoyed our workmen.’

‘Was that affair hot?’

‘Yes, moderately so. We lost five men, and the Rochellais eight or ten.’ ‘*Balzempleu!*’ said the Swiss, who, notwithstanding the admirable collection of oaths possessed by the German language, had acquired a habit of swearing in French.

‘But it is probable,’ said the light-horseman, ‘that they will send pioneers this morning to repair the bastion.’

‘Yes, that’s probable,’ said D’Artagnan.

‘Gentlemen,’ said Athos, ‘a wager!’

‘Ah, *wooi*, a wager!’ cried the Swiss.

‘What is it?’ said the light-horseman.

‘Stop a bit,’ said the dragoon, placing his saber like a spit upon the two large iron dogs which held the firebrands in the chimney, ‘stop a bit, I am in it. You cursed host! a dripping pan immediately, that I may not lose a drop of the fat of this estimable bird.’

‘You was right,’ said the Swiss; ‘goose grease is kood with basdry.’

‘There!’ said the dragoon. ‘Now for the wager! We listen, Monsieur Athos.’

‘Yes, the wager!’ said the light-horseman.

‘Well, Monsieur de Busigny, I will bet you,’ said Athos, ‘that my three companions, Messieurs Porthos, Aramis, and D’Artagnan, and myself, will go and breakfast in the bastion St. Gervais, and we will remain there an hour, by the watch, whatever the enemy may do to dislodge us.’

Porthos and Aramis looked at each other; they began to comprehend.

'But,' said D'Artagnan, in the ear of Athos, 'you are going to get us all killed without mercy.'

'We are much more likely to be killed,' said Athos, 'if we do not go.'

'My faith, gentlemen,' said Porthos, turning round upon his chair and twisting his moustache, 'that's a fair bet, I hope.'

'I take it,' said M. de Busigny, 'so let us fix the stake.'

'You are four gentlemen,' said Athos, 'and we are four; an unlimited dinner for eight. Will that do?'

'Capitally,' replied M. de Busigny.

'Perfectly,' said the dragon.

'That shoots me,' said the Swiss.

The fourth auditor, who during all this conversation had played a mute part, made a sign of the head in proof that he acquiesced in the proposition.

'The breakfast for these gentlemen is ready,' said the host.

'Well, bring it,' said Athos.

The host obeyed. Athos called Grimaud, pointed to a large basket which lay in a corner, and made a sign to him to wrap the viands up in the napkins.

Grimaud understood that it was to be a breakfast on the grass, took the basket, packed up the viands, added the bottles, and then took the basket on his arm.

'But where are you going to eat my breakfast?' asked the host.

'What matter, if you are paid for it?' said Athos, and he threw two pistols majestically on the table.

'Shall I give you the change, my officer?' said the host.

'No, only add two bottles of champagne, and the difference will be for the napkins.'

The host had not quite so good a bargain as he at first hoped for, but he made amends by slipping in two bottles of Anjou wine instead of two bottles of champagne.

'Monsieur de Busigny,' said Athos, 'will you be so kind as to set your watch with mine, or permit me to regulate mine by yours?'

'Which you please, monsieur!' said the light-horseman, drawing from his fob a very handsome watch, studded with diamonds, 'half past seven.'

'The devil, gentlemen!' said the cardinal, 'three men placed *hors de combat* in a cabaret squabble! You don't do your work by halves. And pray what was this quarrel about?'

'These fellows were drunk,' said Athos, 'and knowing there was a lady who had arrived at the cabaret this evening, they wanted to force her door.'

'Force her door?' said the cardinal, 'and for what purpose?'

'To do her violence, without doubt,' said Athos. 'I have had the honour of informing your Eminence that these men were drunk.'

'And was this lady young and handsome?' asked the cardinal, with a certain degree of anxiety.

'We did not see her, monseigneur,' said Athos.

'You did not see her? Ah, very well,' replied the cardinal, quickly. 'You did well to defend the honour of a woman; and as I am going to the Red Dovecot myself, I shall know if you have told me the truth.'

'Monseigneur,' said Athos, haughtily, 'we are gentlemen, and to save our heads we would not be guilty of a falsehood.'

'Therefore I do not doubt what you say, Monsieur Athos, I do not doubt it for a single instant; but,' added he, 'to change the conversation, was this lady alone?'

'The lady had a cavalier shut up with her,' said Athos, 'but as notwithstanding the noise, this cavalier did not show himself, it is to be presumed that he is a coward.'

'Judge not rashly,' says the Gospel,' replied the cardinal.

Athos bowed.

'And now, gentlemen, that's well,' continued the cardinal. 'I know what I wish to know; follow me.'

The three Musketeers passed behind his Eminence, who again enveloped his face in his cloak, and put his horse in motion, keeping from eight to ten paces in advance of his four companions.

They soon arrived at the silent, solitary inn. No doubt the host knew what illustrious visitor was expected, and had consequently sent intruders out of the way.

Ten paces from the door the cardinal made a sign to his esquire and the three Musketeers to halt. A saddled horse was fastened to the window shutter. The cardinal knocked three times, and in a peculiar manner.